

More Elim Chan; Fewer Lang Lang
Ruoping Wang
July 2026

Elim Chan, a 39-year-old Chinese classical musician, has just made history. She will become the next Music Director of the San Francisco Symphony Orchestra--the first female conductor in the Orchestra's 115 years of history. In fact, she is the very first female to take such a position in any of the seven major symphony orchestras in the United States: Chicago, Cleveland, Boston, Philadelphia, New York, Los Angeles, and San Francisco.

In 2014, Elim was the first female ever to win the prestigious Donatella Flick London Symphony Orchestra Conducting Competition. Since then, she has guest-conducted top orchestras around the world, including the famed Boston Symphonic Orchestra. With such dazzling achievements, Elim breaks a glass ceiling in the world of classical music, where the conductor's role was, until recently, exclusively occupied by men.

Elim's education and career path were somewhat atypical for a musician of her standing. She was born and raised in Hong Kong. Her parents were artists but not musicians.

Early in childhood, she learned to play piano and sing in choirs--just like many ordinary kids from ordinary middle-class families do. She wasn't a child prodigy destined to become a musician. In fact, after high school, she attended Smith College in the United States majoring in psychology. She planned to go to medical school after college. But at Smith, through singing in and conducting choirs, her talent for music was recognized by her teachers. With their recommendation, she did graduate studies in classical music at the University of Michigan, earning master's and PhD degrees in conducting.

In a TV interview, Elim recalled difficult times in her early career. With a master's degree from Michigan, she went back to Hong Kong to look for a job, "any job," as a classical musician. Of that experience, she said, "No one would hire me, because I wasn't a child prodigy well known in Hong Kong, nor had I won any awards." Her break in career only came after she won the Donatella Flick Competition.

Elim may be a late bloomer as a musician. Because of that, and, maybe also, because her parents did not drive her too hard to become someone outstanding, she seemed to have enjoyed a normal childhood and adolescence. She had the opportunity to explore broad

education before focusing on music. Reading her bio, I could not help but compare her story with that of another iconic classical musician in China, Lang Lang.

In 2004, a 22-year-old pianist Lang Lang debuted in the music world by performing with the Berlin Philharmonic Orchestra—arguably, the best in the world—with astonishing success. He was the first Chinese instrumentalist to have the privilege of collaborating with the Berlin Philharmonic Orchestra. After that he became the first Chinese to win other prestigious awards and contracts. His success is a sensation in China, and he remains an idol for aspiring Chinese musicians.

Lang is to China as Andrea Bocelli is to Italy. Like the latter, who sang at the 2026 Winter Olympics in Italy, Lang played piano at the 2008 Summer Olympics in Beijing.

Lang is a household name in China. So is his father, but for entirely different reasons.

In Chinese media, Lang's father is nicknamed "Wolf Dad," which is the Chinese version of "Tiger Mom" from the book *"Battle Hymn of the Tiger Mom"* by Amy Chua. He is a Wolf Dad, figuratively, because of the way he raised his

son; and, literally, because his last name "Lang" is homophonic with the word for wolf in Chinese.

The older Lang played a Chinese musical instrument called Er Hu for a low-level military band. He might have some music talents of his own, but that did not take him far in his time and with his circumstances. He was bitter about his own lot. Like many Chinese parents, the older Lang hoped that his unfulfilled dreams would be fulfilled by his son.

When the older Lang saw that his son was gifted, he went all out to put him under a grueling, even cruel, schedule of lessons and practice, depriving him of any other activities and fun. Once, little Lang Lang came home from school a little late after hanging out with classmates. His father scolded him so harshly that he threatened to jump to his death if his father would not stop.

Lang Lang was a tough kid. He survived his unreasonable father and matured normally, although with scars. He graduated from a top conservatory in China, and then, the Curtis School of Music in the United States. In addition to his fame, he enjoys great commercial success. He is actively involved in music education in China. He is married to a fellow Chinese pianist and they have a son. There have never been any scandals about his personal

and professional life. By all accounts, Lang Lang's story has a happy ending.

However, Lang Lang's pain from childhood did not simply vanish with his success. He chose to share his story with the press to vent at his father and to heal his pain. The older Lang was hurt and embarrassed that his "devotion"—in his view—to his son had earned him the infamous title "Wolf Dad," making him a target of laughter and condemnation in the media. He never apologized for or reflected on his way of fathering, saying only that it is too painful to look back.

Lang Lang reconciled with his father. I haven't read about how he did it. But, based on my own experience, I can imagine the journey of his heart. As time passed, he probably grew to be more appreciative of his father's dedication to him, and to be able to put his childhood experience in perspective.

The older Lang may have an obsessive temperament. Other than that, he was simply practicing the Chinese tradition of "Expect your daughter to become a phoenix; your son a dragon." This long tradition, call it parent's vanity or tough love, is still deeply rooted in Chinese parents, even those living in the West, like Amy Chua who is a Law Professor at Yale.

Also, China was very poor at that time. For a kid from an ordinary family, success not only meant prestige, but was also the ticket to escape poverty. At that time, China had just started its economic reform. No one could have envisioned the miracle it would bring about--that so many people would become so much richer in such a short time. No one, surely not the older Lang, could even imagine that, in his son's generation, ordinary people could live a comfortable, decent, middle-class life. Therefore, parents like the older Lang would do anything they could to make their kids "phoenix and dragon," failing that the kids would live a harsh material life. "Happy childhood" was a concept unknown to most parents. Still, some parents were easier on their kids. The older Lang let his anxiety get the better of him and went to the extreme.

Eilm Chan and Lang Lang are just four years apart in age. But one was born and raised in rich, westernized Hong Kong. Her father was a professor in fine arts who could afford to send her to an expensive private college in the USA to pursue a major of her liking, and to continue supporting her when her music talents and passion beckoned her. The other was born in a poor city of then poor China to a poorly educated father with a poorly

paying job and had to win scholarships all way through college and graduate school. The contrast is stark.

The good news is that, in today's China, kids grow up in environments more like Elim's and less like Lang's. Most people have negative views of Lang's childhood despite his later success. Schools and parents have learned to respect kid's choice, listen to them, work with them, inspire them and support them, rather than forcing them into a career path that they consider the best for the kids. Many parents are well-off enough to help kids follow their seemingly peculiar and impractical dreams. The best example may be the story of Jiao Zi.

Jiao Zi was a young college student of Chinese medicine in Sichuan, China. He realized that his heart was not in medicine but in cartoons, a hobby he has had since childhood. So, he quit college to teach himself professional cartoon drawing. He and his widowed mother lived on her meager, but survivable, retirement salary for three years. Then he won the top prize in a cartoon drawing competition and started getting commissioned by the entertainment industry. He went on to produce and direct a blockbuster Chinese animation movie series, *Ne Zha*. In 2024, *Ne Zha 2* came to the theater as an instant and phenomenal success. It was the first Chinese movie ever to have been ranked #1 in the global box office.

I recently watched a video of young Elim conducting the Dutch National Symphonic Orchestra seven years ago. She looked so confident with her baton, so young--even still having baby fat, and so comfortable with herself. I'm very happy for this girl: a girl who had the luxury to pursue her career and passion freely in her own choice of time; a girl, while having ascended to the very top rungs of career ladder, nevertheless also lives a colorful and happy life. She enjoys boxing in her spare time and is married to a fellow classical musician, a Dutch percussionist. I cheered for her on TV: Go, Elim. Good to you!